



If you feel forced to dip into your savings in an emergency, consider it a loan. If you can't pay it all back at once, set up a repayment plan and pay yourself as though it were a regular bill. Otherwise you may never replenish your savings.

Use windfalls to pump up your savings instead of spending them. Bonuses, tax refunds, rebates, overtime pay, income from hobbies or yard sales, cash gifts from family, lottery winnings, and other sporadic cash receipts can make faster advances toward your goals without requiring additional spending cutbacks. When you receive a salary increase, put all or part of it into savings each pay period and continue living on your previous salary. When you pay off a loan, continue putting the payment amount aside each month, but pay it into your savings account instead of to the bank or finance company. Because you're already in the habit of doing without that money, you won't even miss it.

Don't Be a Victim of Advertising

With a spending plan, you don't need to deprive yourself of things you really need, but you should question whether you really do need them. Experts recommend these strategies:

- Don't use shopping as a form of recreation.
 - Don't shop on impulse.
 - For items you really do need, look for sales and special offers.
 - Shop at outlet or discount stores and websites.
 - Before buying appliances, electronics, computer equipment, and other expensive items, research them in *Consumer Reports* or other magazines that do consumer reviews.
 - Do some of your shopping at a warehouse club, if there's one near you.
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